

Research Interests

Explainable Recommendation, Recommender Systems, Large Language Models, Natural Language Generation

Education

Ph.D. of Computer Science

Hong Kong Baptist University (HKBU)

Advisor: [Prof. Li Chen](#), Mentors: [Dr. Yongfeng Zhang](#) & [Dr. Ruihai Dong](#)

Aug. 2017 – Nov. 2022

- Thesis: *Natural Language Explanation for Recommendations and Beyond*
- Studied recurrent neural networks (RNN), Transformer and large language models (LLM) for recommendation explanation generation, and published 3 papers at CIKM'20, ACL'21 and TOIS
- Major research outcome integrated into a small eco-system [NLG4RS](#) for recommender systems-based natural language generation that includes benchmark datasets, evaluation metrics and representative models, and that has been widely adopted

B.Eng. of Computer Science & B.Sc. of Mathematics

Shenzhen University (SZU)

Advisor: [Prof. Weike Pan](#)

Sep. 2013 – Jun. 2017

- Research on recommendation algorithms, especially collaborative filtering and matrix factorization

Experiences

Shenzhen University

Aug. 2025 – Present

Assistant Professor

Shenzhen, China

- Research on trustworthy issues of LLM-based recommender systems

Hong Kong Baptist University

Aug. 2022 – Jul. 2025

Post-doctoral Research Fellow Advisor: [Prof. Li Chen](#), Mentor: [Dr. Yongfeng Zhang](#)

Hong Kong, China

- Supported by Hong Kong Research Grants Council (RGC) and Huawei
- Research on LLM-based recommendation

Rutgers University

Feb. 2023 – Jun. 2023

Visiting Researcher Advisor: [Dr. Yongfeng Zhang](#)

New Brunswick, USA

- Published 1 paper about efficient LLM-based recommendation at CIKM'23

Suishou Technology

Aug. 2016 – Nov. 2016

Intern Advisor: [Prof. Weike Pan](#)

Shenzhen, China

- Utilized machine learning tools (such as Liblinear and XGBoost) to mine potential customers for personalized advertising
- Increased the company's sales of financial products by 4 times during an online test

Grants

HKSTP Ideation Programme

Sep. 2024 – Aug. 2025

Palm (an app that provides the elderly with customized recommendations of finger exercises)

HK\$50K

RGC Postdoctoral Fellowship Scheme (PDFS)

Aug. 2022 – Jul. 2025

Causal Inference for Natural Language Processing in Recommender Systems

HK\$1.24M

Selected Publications (citation 1000+, h-index 13)

- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Dugang Liu, Li Chen. Large Language Models for Generative Recommendation: A Survey and Visionary Discussions. Proceedings of the 2024 Joint International Conference on Computational Linguistics, Language Resources and Evaluation (**COLING'24**), pages 10146-10159, Turin, Italy, May 20–25, 2024. (**citation 100+**)
- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Li Chen. Prompt Distillation for Efficient LLM-based Recommendation. Proceedings of the 32nd ACM International Conference on Information and Knowledge Management (**CIKM'23**), pages 1348-1357, Birmingham, United Kingdom, October 21–25, 2023. (**citation 100+**)
- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Li Chen. Personalized Prompt Learning for Explainable Recommendation. ACM Transactions on Information Systems (**TOIS**), volume 41 (4), article 103, pages 1-26, March 2023. (**citation 200+**)
- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Li Chen. On the Relationship between Explanation and Recommendation: Learning to Rank Explanations for Improved Performance. ACM Transactions on Intelligent Systems and Technology (**TIST**), volume 14 (2), article 21, pages 1-24, February 2023
- Dugang Liu, Weihao Du, **Lei Li**, Weike Pan, Zhong Ming. Augmenting Legal Judgment Prediction with Contrastive Case Relations. Proceedings of the 29th International Conference on Computational Linguistics (**COLING'22**), pages 2658-2667, Gyeongju, Republic of Korea, October 12–17, 2022
- Shijie Geng, Zuohui Fu, Yingqiang Ge, **Lei Li**, Gerard de Melo, Yongfeng Zhang. Improving Personalized Explanation Generation through Visualization. Proceedings of the 60th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics (**ACL'22**), pages 244-255, Dublin, Ireland, May 22–27, 2022
- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Li Chen. Personalized Transformer for Explainable Recommendation. Proceedings of the 59th Annual Meeting of the Association for Computational Linguistics and the 11th International Joint Conference on Natural Language Processing (**ACL'21 oral**), pages 4947-4957, Online, Thailand, August 1–6, 2021. (**citation 200+**)
- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Li Chen. EXTRA: Explanation Ranking Datasets for Explainable Recommendation. Proceedings of the 44th International ACM SIGIR Conference on Research and Development in Information Retrieval (**SIGIR'21**), pages 2463-2469, Virtual Event, Canada, July 11–15, 2021
- **Lei Li**, Yongfeng Zhang, Li Chen. Generate Neural Template Explanations for Recommendation. Proceedings of the 29th ACM International Conference on Information & Knowledge Management (**CIKM'20**), pages 755-764, Virtual Event, Ireland, October 19–23, 2020. (**citation 100+**)

Talks**Recent Trends in Recommender Systems Community (RecSys 2024)**

Nov. 2024

Professors' Insights Gained from Top Conferences

Huawei (Online)

Conversational Recommender Systems and Recent Trends Driven by LLMs

Oct. 2024

Summer School at RecSys'24

Bari

Large Language Models for Generative Recommendation

Apr. 2024

ConsumerBG AI Workshop Hong Kong

Huawei Hong Kong Research Center

Large Language Models for Generative Recommendation

Apr. 2024

Huawei Computing Youth Forum

Hangzhou

Large Language Models for Recommendation

Sep. 2023

Tutorial at RecSys'23

Singapore

Attracted hundreds of attendees

Generating Recommendation Explanations with Transformer and Pre-trained Model	Mar. 2023
Data Science Lab	Korea Advanced Institute of Science & Technology (Online)
Improving Personalized Explanation Generation through Visualization	Dec. 2022
Department of Computer Science	University of Luxembourg (Online)
How to Come up with Ideas and Do Research: Experience Sharing	Oct. 2021
COMP7160 Research Methods in Computer Science	Hong Kong Baptist University

Academic Services

- **Guest Editor:** ACM Transactions on Recommender Systems (TORS) special issue on “Large Language Models for Recommender Systems”, 2023 – 2025
- **Workshop Organizer:**
 - “EARL: The 2nd Workshop on Evaluating and Applying Recommender Systems with Large Language Models”. RecSys’25
 - “EARL: Workshop on Evaluating and Applying Recommendation Systems with Large Language Models”. RecSys’24
- **Session Chair:** CIKM’23, WWW’23
- **Program Committee Member:** KDD’25, RecSys’24, WWW’23, RecSys’22
- **Invited Reviewer:** IEEE TKDE, ACM TOIS, ACM TORS, ACM TIST, IEEE TBD, IJHCS, ACM TiIS, NEUCOM, KNOSYS, JIIS
- **External Reviewer:** CIKM’24, SIGIR’21, WWW’21, WWW’19

Awards & Honors

RPg Performance Award	HKBU	Sep. 2021
Research Postgraduate Studentship	HKBU	Aug. 2017 – Aug. 2021
Research Excellence Award	PG Day, HKBU	Jun. 2021
Best Presentation Award	PG Day, HKBU	Jun. 2020
Excellent Teaching Assistant Performance Award	HKBU	Jun. 2018, 2019, 2020
Teaching Assistant Performance Award	HKBU	Feb. 2020
Outstanding Graduate	SZU	Jun. 2017

Technical Skills

Programming Language	Python, Java, Matlab, C++ (ordered by proficiency)
Platform and Tool	PyTorch, TensorFlow, Scikit-learn, MongoDB, Django, XGBoost, Liblinear

Languages

Mandarin	Native
English	Working proficiency
Cantonese	Elementary

Last update: October 11, 2025